Ten Essentials Checklist

Carry all 10 systems, every trip.

THE TEN ESSENTIAL SYSTEMS — CARRY ALL 10, EVERY TRIP

- ☐ 1. Navigation: Topo map + compass + GPS/phone with offline maps. Know how to use them all.
- ☐ 2. Headlamp: LED headlamp + extra batteries. Test before every trip. Hands-free light.
- ☐ 3. Sun Protection: SPF 30+ sunscreen, UV sunglasses, hat, lip balm with SPF. Reapply every 2 hrs.
- ☐ 4. First Aid Kit: Bandages, gauze, tape, pain meds, blister care, personal meds. Check dates.
- ☐ 5. Knife + Repair: Multi-tool, duct tape (3+ ft), cord/ paracord (50 ft), zip ties, safety pins.
- ☐ 6. Fire Starting: Waterproof matches AND lighter + fire starter. Both — redundancy matters.
- ☐ 7. Emergency Shelter: Bivy, space blanket, or ultralight tarp. Practice setup at home first.
- ☐ 8. Extra Food: 1+ extra day's worth. Bars, nuts, jerky, peanut butter. No cooking required.
- ☐ 9. Extra Water: 1L+ extra + purification (filter, tablets, or UV). Pre-hydrate before hike.
- ☐ 10. Extra Clothing: Insulating layer, rain jacket + pants, warm hat, gloves. NO COTTON.

FIELD TIPS

- ☐ Total weight: A complete kit weighs only 3-5 lbs. There is no excuse to skip it.
- ☐ Cotton kills: Loses ALL insulation when wet. Wool or synthetic materials only.
- ☐ Cold batteries: Lose 20-40% capacity in cold. Keep phone and headlamp in inside pockets.
- ☐ Pre-hydrate: Drink 16 oz in the hour before you start. Dark urine = already dehydrated.
- ☐ Keep it packed: Dedicated bag, always ready to grab. Check expiration dates each season.

MOST RESCUES INVOLVE DAY HIKERS

The majority of people we rescue planned to be out for 'just a few hours.' Afternoon weather, a wrong turn, or a minor injury can turn a short hike into an overnight. Always pack as if you might spend the night out. Pierce County spans sea level to 14,411 ft (Mt. Rainier) — prepare for the highest point on your route.